

The Voice Express

what
The Truth Takes Time. distant

EDUCATION

The Endemic Ecosystems of DU Sub Fests: CADET’23

A dispatch from Kirori Mal College's CADET’23 — Delhi University's annual NCC fest — where twenty-three institutions gathered and found, as usual, nothing much to say to one another. On the recursive culture of apathy that defines DU's sub-fest circuit.

BY MOULI SHARMA



Photo: Mouli Sharma

New Delhi: The 9th of February kicked off the annual NCC fest of Delhi University's old, prestigious, big-name alumnus-heavy Kirori Mal College. Boys and girls in combat uniforms with 5kg Aashirvad Aatta equivalent rifle dummies carried out the section attack on the front lawns (“arrowhead formation” “classic”) as a crowd consisting of 30-person teams along with their moral supporters of over 23 institutions (including those from outside of the directorate) surrounded the grounds looking anywhere but at them.

Culture finds a way.

The world is recursive. Society recreates itself within itself, and whether it be an unmoving resilience of the human spirit or a biological vulnerability to the goddamn sound of bleating, a man will create tradition where he cannot find it, if only so he has something to get used to.

The various niches of DU Fests - departmental, ECA, NCC, NSS, what have you - are a case study in self-sustaining ecosystems. A “normal” person walking into the gates of CADET’23 (excellent name, by the way, truly an epitome of the spirit of originality and creativity the military and modern education are so insistent upon inculcating) will find certain sights to gaze upon. Goats in a petting zoo. Infiltrators in a cult. Look how they greet each other, arms a stiff set by their sides, white lie caressing their lips (“Jai Hind everyone”). Look what they care about, creases on their pants and 3 buttons over their waists. Look how they think; they don’t.

Somewhere past the point of no return of zoning out on the rifles aimed directly between my eyes as the section attack droned on, my friend had thrust a green piece of sponge and a white bottle of shoeshine into my hands. Multipurpose polish, that’s what she’d called it.

“What, seriously?”

“Seriously.”

“Fuck off.”

“Maybe just polish it yourself then. She’s doing it, isn’t she?”

“Yeah I’m doing it, just shut the fuck up.”

“That’s enough! I’ll do it,” said my friend. Owner of and first in line for the polish, and incidentally, the Junior Under Officer of our company. The senior most in our batch.

CULTURE

Absent in the Spring

A review of Agatha Christie's 1944 psychological novel written under the pseudonym Mary Westmacott — a departure from her detective fiction that follows Joan Scudamore, stranded in the Iraqi desert and forced, for the first time, to reckon with the lies she has built her life around.

BY MOULI SHARMA

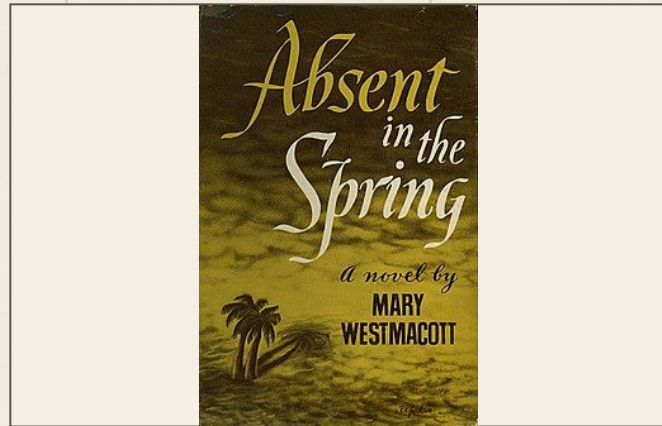


Photo: Mouli Sharma

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“No, you can’t,” the whiner said. Took her shoe off the ledge.

“Put it back up.”

“Please don’t.”

“What did I say?”

For the life of that dying bottle, dear old JUO managed to polish every single one of those 9 pairs of drill march shoes, some better than others. She stood there frowning beside me after the formality of brushing a dry sponge over her own shoes and wordlessly handed her precious materials back over to me.

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“This is pretty wet,” I’d said then. Silence.

“Probably still has a substantial amount of polish in it.” I lent over and pressed the last dredges of multipurpose shoeshine onto her dust-covered boots. Best I could.

“It works on normal shoes, too.”

“That’s nice.”

“I said, it works on normal shoes, too.”

GENDER

Aurat ke Haq Mein

A review of Taslima Nasrin's 'Aurat ke Haq Mein' — a searing feminist work that refuses to make peace with the patriarchal structures that silence women, and asks the questions that religious fundamentalists and compliant societies alike would rather go unanswered.

BY MOULI SHARMA

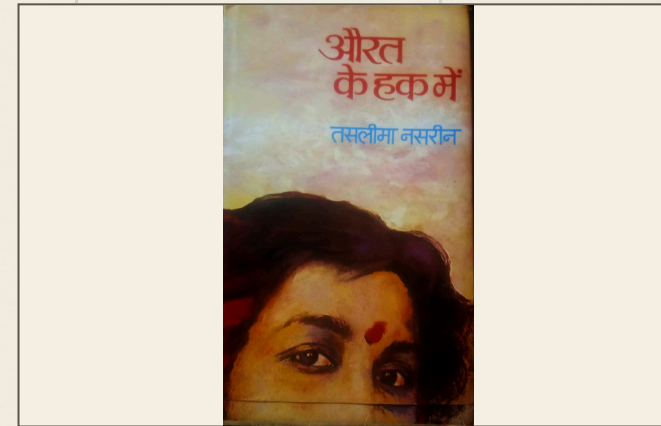


Photo: Mouli Sharma

पुस्तक:- औरत के हक में
लेखिका:- तस्लीमा नसरिन
अनुवादक:- मुस्तुन सरकार
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पिनुस्तात्मक समाज में बहुत सारी महिलाओं की आवाज़ें दब जाती हैं या दबा दिया जाता है। नारी - स्वतंत्रता से जुड़े विचार अथवा आंदोलन बहुत नए नहीं हैं पर 21 वीं सदी में भी स्त्री - पुरुष के बीच में कुल्लेम असमानताएं मौजूद हैं। ऐसे टीड में तस्लीमा अपने उपन्यास " औरत के हक में " में सटीक और सही प्रश्न पूछती हैं जो ना सिर्फ धार्मिक कट्टरवादियों को चुभता है बल्कि हर उस मानसिकता को टक्कर देता है जो स्त्री को आज भी भोग्या के नज़रिए से देखते हैं । तस्लीमा नसरिन अपने इस उपन्यास में अपने जाल्मकाल से अब तक के जीवन में घटी निर्मम घटनाओं को उलिक किया है और इसके प्रकाश में नए सवाल भी पूछा है । यह एक ऐसी पुस्तक है , जिसे प्रत्येक औरत को अवश्य पढ़ना चाहिए जिससे वे सब यह समझ सकें कि उनके आस - पास उन्हें दिग्भ्रमित करने के लिए कितनी जानें बिछाई गई हैं। वे समझ सकें की उन्हें खुद को बिना रूपी ताकत से खुद को बख़्श करना होगा जिससे वे सारे बंधनों को तोड़ सकें , सारे बंधियों को पिचला सकें जो वस्तुतः उन्हें बांधने या जकड़ने का प्रयास करते हैं। तस्लीमा के सवाल विज्ञान के ताकिकला पे खड़े उठते हैं , स्त्रीयों को स्वायत्तता के लिए तयार करते हैं । यह सत्ता , समाज और धर्म के सारे अघनिश्चास और नियमों पे सवाल खड़ा करती हैं जो प्रत्यक्ष या अप्रत्यक्ष तौर पे महिला को अबला या कलंकित मानते हैं।

Photo: Mouli Sharma

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I looked up at her and her eyes moved down to my shoes and back to me. She raised an eyebrow. I rolled my eyes and pressed the sponge down on my own no longer black sport shoes. She smiled.

“See?”
“I do.”
“It’s useful, isn’t it.”
“They don’t need polish, dude they need a turbo wash.”

“Yeah, but if you polished them you wouldn’t have to turbo wash them.”

I gave her a look. She smiled.
The best you can hope for in life is people you’d douse your sports shoes in wax for. A multipurpose polish that works on all kinds of shoes. A dummy rifle that slaps back. A tug of war rope that isn’t long enough. Good fest or bad fest because everything everyone everywhere is the same. The best you can hope for is to find something you cannot predict.

Absent in the Spring · CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

In the 1940s, a middle-aged woman named Joan Scudamore makes a solo trip from Baghdad to Kirkuk to visit her husband, who works for an oil company. She is stranded in her home for a few days because of a sudden sandstorm, and during that time, she starts to think back on her relationships and life. She learns that she has been so preoccupied with trying to satisfy other people and fit in with social norms that she has lost sight of her own wants and individuality. Joan comes to the realization that she has been portraying a fake self to everyone, even her own family, and has been living a lie. When she starts to accept who she really is, Joan's epiphany is both upsetting and empowering.

The book is exquisitely written and displays Christie's talent for telling tales. It digs into the intricacies of interpersonal interactions and the challenges of comprehending one's own emotions and intentions. Readers will identify with Joan's complex and likable character as she attempts to understand her inner conflicts.

Aurat ke Haq Mein · CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

प्रस्तुत हैं पुस्तक के कुछ अंश:-

'नष्ट' या 'कलंकित' या 'पतित' शब्द पुरुषों के लिए नहीं स्त्रियों के लिए व्यवहृत होते हैं। जैसे की अंडे खराब हो जाते हैं , दूध बर्बाद हो जाता है , नारियल सर जाता है वैसे ही औरत 'पतित' हो जाती हैं । हमारे समाज में ऐसी ही दूसरी तमाम चीज़ों की तरह ऐसी किसी स्त्री को भी 'नष्ट' 'बर्बाद' या 'पतिता' कहा जाता हैं। इस देश की शिक्षित और रुचिसंपन्न युवतियां इन तमाम बर्बाद या 'पतिता' युवतियों से अपने को अलग - थलग रखने के मामले में बड़ी चौकस रहती हैं। अपने को अलग थलग रखना मूर्खता है क्योंकि जहां किसी - न - किसी रूप में तमाम औरतें सलाई जा रही हैं वहां इस तरह के किसी वर्ग - भेद या श्रेणी - भेद का कोई सवाल ही नहीं उठता । यह भ्रष्ट समाज तो इसी ताक में रहता हैं की जरा - सा मौका मिला नहीं की लड़कियों को 'नष्ट' या 'बर्बाद' को संज्ञा दे देता हैं।

~ शिल्पी कुमारी



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